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For six weeks, the country that had spent decades calling football soccer could talk about little else.

The game poured into the United States through its airports and railway stations, occupied its downtowns and suburbs, and turned stadium parking lots into temporary republics of colour, song and shared obsession. Argentines carried their mate through hotel lobbies. Mexicans arrived with sombreros and booming brass bands. Brazilians brought drums, Colombians danced, the English colonised pubs, and supporters from countries separated by oceans discovered one another on trains, concourses and

pavements.

In New York, Philadelphia, Boston, Atlanta, Miami, Dallas, Los Angeles and the other host cities, football was no longer an immigrant game.

For one extraordinary summer, it had taken over the American psyche.

The United States has always possessed the infrastructure for sporting excess: enormous arenas, endless commercial possibilities, a culture fluent in spectacle and a population drawn from nearly every footballing nation on earth. The World Cup brought all those elements together on a scale the tournament had never previously attempted.

Forty-eight nations, 1,039 players and 104 matches produced 308

goals at an average of 2.96 per game. A record 6,810,966 spectators attended, more than the combined totals of the previous two World Cups in Russia and Qatar. The 16 venues operated at 99.7 per cent capacity, with an average attendance of 65,490.

The figures described the tournament's size. They could not fully capture its presence.

There were supporters who crossed continents and families who crossed generations. Fathers who had discovered Argentina through Diego Maradona returned with sons who had fallen in love with Lionel Messi. Children wore the shirts of countries they had never visited. Diaspora communities that usually